



deep sense of mourning. Assam was grieving the tragic death of Zubeen Garg, who drowned while swimming in Singapore. One of the state's greatest cultural icons, Garg had become a household name across India with his hit song *Ya Ali* from the 2006 Bollywood film *Gangster*.

His smiling face looked down from billboards all over Guwahati, and his music echoed in the tributes paid at the World Cup's inaugural ceremony, held shortly before India's opening match against Sri Lanka. Among the performers was Shreya Ghoshal, whose voice carried a fitting note of remembrance.

Siddhartha Das was in for a surprise after finishing his net session at Guwahati's Barsapara Cricket Stadium, where he had been bowling to the South African batters. A member of the visiting support staff approached him and handed over a pair of batting gloves.

It was a gift from South Africa captain Laura Wolvaardt to Siddhartha, who had bowled some 50 deliveries to her as she prepared to face England's spinners. "I have enjoyed watching her on TV," said Siddhartha, a left-arm spinner and trainee at the Assam Cricket Association Academy. "She played a

Net reward: Assam's Siddhartha Das with the gloves gifted by South Africa skipper Laura Wolvaardt — a keepsake from a memorable net session at Barsapara Stadium.

P. K. AJITH KUMAR

lot of cover drives and straight drives against me. And, of course, I am delighted that she has given me a pair of her gloves."

In the early days of the World Cup, a cab driver in Guwahati brought up India's opening match against Sri Lanka. "India would have been in big trouble but for Deepti Sharma's innings," said Sajeevan, a driver from Kerala, referring to the off-spinning all-rounder's rescue act with Amanjot Kaur that took India from a precarious 124 for six to what would become a match-winning total.

Listening to him brought to mind an interview with Smriti Mandhana in Jaipur about six years ago. The elegant opener had said, "Earlier, people would say that the off-spinner bowled well. Now they say Deepti Sharma bowled well."

P. K. Ajith Kumar

Garba night with a twist

A trip to Indore, set against the

Revelry: Dancers whirl in rhythm at the Taal Garba Mahotsav in Indore, their synchronised steps capturing the city's festive pulse on a night when cricket met celebration.

SANKAR NARAYANAN E.H.

backdrop of Navratri, offered the perfect opportunity for the Diary to witness its first Garba celebration, and it proved a memorable one.

A hesitant enquiry by this reporter, on the eve of the Women's ODI World Cup match between Australia and New Zealand at the Holkar Stadium, was all it took for the venue manager and a few local journalists to make some calls and secure a ticket.

The destination was the *Taal Garba Mahotsav*, held at a school sports complex just across the street.

As the night wore on and the tempo of the synchronised steps quickened, the synergy and energy in the performance evoked amusement and wide-eyed wonder.

Madhya Pradesh's very own and Kolkata Knight Riders all-rounder Venkatesh Iyer making his way to the dais to give away the prizes was a delightful surprise that capped off the night for the Diary.

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